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Introduction

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Now that we have discussed the core chapters of your report, we move on to the more specialized chapters: Introduction, Summary and Conclusions. These three chapters are essential in helping your reader find the information he or she is looking for. And although the information they contain may overlap heavily, they each have their own role to play:

The *Summary* is a stand-alone document, and will often be the first chapter a reader will look at. To create a coherent stand-alone document, the summary must explain the problem, the main methods used to study it, and the main conclusions drawn in the report. A reader should be able to use the summary to see if the report is relevant for him.

If the reader decides to truly read your report, the *Introduction* is generally the next bit to read. In this chapter, the focus lies on the problem studied in the report. It should include background information and context, motivation to study this topic, and then a clear outline of the problem studied in the report. Additionally, you should give your reader an idea of the limitations of your modelling results. Finally, your introduction should outline what will happen in the rest of your report. This provides a road-map (including chapter numbers!) of where to find what information.

The *Conclusions* chapter comes near the end of the report, and will focus on the results of your modelling effort. To keep this chapter coherent, you should once again state the problem that you study, but most of the chapter should be devoted to answering the questions you have posed yourself.

Keep in mind that not every reader will read every chapter of your report, which explains why information will need to be repeated. And even for a thorough reader, it can be very convenient to have a complete and coherent story to read in the Conclusions chapter, without needing to look up the precise statements of work done in previous chapters.

Our first focus for this unit will be the introduction.

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The video above outlines the purpose of the Introduction chapter, and the components it contains:

- Background and context for the research project
- Motivation

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- Outline for the report

These components may each consist of one or several paragraphs, as discussed before.

Use the exercises below to get an idea of what these components may look like.
Afterwards, try to come up with a rough outline for your own introduction.

Exercise A

1/1 point (graded)

What is true about the introduction of a report?

☒ The introduction tells the readers what to expect in the rest of the report. ✓

☐ The introduction gives a summary of the whole report.

☐ The introduction contains a conclusion.

☐ The introduction contains acknowledgements.

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Exercise B

1/1 point (graded)

Which element is always present in an introduction?

☐ A table

☐ A figure

☒ A purpose statement / main question ✓

☐ A conclusion

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Exercise C

1/1 point (graded)

 Keyboard Help

PROBLEM

The following elements are always present in an introduction. In what order should they appear?

1

Background information

2

Motive for the research

3

Purpose statement / research
questions

4

Limitations, requirements

5

Structural overview per chapter

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FEEDBACK

✓ Correctly placed 5 items.

✓ Good work! You have correctly ordered your introduction

✓ Your highest score is 1.0

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Read the following text.

Every satellite that orbits the Earth has certain orbit characteristics, and since the orbit of the mission is usually what makes or breaks the mission, it is necessary to determine, describe and predict the orbit of any future mission, so that the right orbit is chosen for the right mission.

The text is part of an introduction. Which function does it have?

- ☐ Background information
- ☒ Motive for the research (why was this report written?) ✓
- ☐ Purpose statement / research question
- ☐ Limitations / requirements
- ☐ Structural overview per chapter

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Exercise E

1/1 point (graded)

In this report, a systematical build-up of the orbit determination of the GOCE mission will be done. First, in chapter 2, the theory behind the mission will be explained. By doing an analysis of previous comparable missions, including GRACE and CHAMP, any collected data will be reviewed for usefulness and significance in this mission. In chapter 3 the created Java program will be laid out, using a general structure and the flowchart. Chapter 4 will discuss the results that came from the Java program, when certain information is entered. It will discuss the orbits of the satellite, and the consequences. Finally, an optimal altitude and inclination will be presented for the GOCE mission in the conclusion of this report. Here, any recommendations for future elaborations will also be addressed.

The following text is part of an introduction. Which function does it have?

- ☐ Background information

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☐ Purpose statement / research question

☐ Limitations / requirements

☒ Structural overview per chapter ✓

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Exercise F

1/1 point (graded)

Please read the following text.

After being delayed for more than 3 years, ESA has set another launch date for the Gravity field and steady state Ocean Circulation Explorer (GOCE). The launch is now planned for March 2009. This satellite is supposed to map the planet's gravity and ocean currents with great detail. Using Earth's gravity field and knowledge about ocean currents and temperatures (e.g. el Niño), the environment can be forecast better. In order to predict any future disasters, such as volcano eruptions or tsunamis, the Earth should be studied and observed with as much knowledge and information as possible. For the prosperity and future of mankind, studying the Earth's gravity field is thus very important. Since "getting a global picture" means observing on a global level, observations from space are inevitable.

The text is part of an introduction. Which function does it have?

☒ Background information ✓

☐ Motive for the research (why was this report written?)

☐ Purpose statement / research question

☐ Limitations / requirements

☐ Structural overview per chapter

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i Answers are displayed within the problem

Exercise G

1/1 point (graded)

Read the following text.

The calculations required for this will be explained and assembled in a Java program. Several graphs will plot out the wanted information. Even though this program is a large simplification of reality, leaving many disturbance forces (e.g. drag and solar radiation) unnoted, the outcome of the program resembles the actual flight path of the GOCE satellite. After varying the input data, including inclination and orbit altitude, an ideal orbit for the GOCE mission will be deduced and discussed.

The text is part of an introduction. Which function does it have?

- ☐ Background information
- ☐ Motive for the research (why was this report written?)
- ☐ Purpose statement / research question
- ☒ Limitations / requirements ✓
- ☐ Structural overview per chapter

Submit

You have used 1 of 3 attempts

i Answers are displayed within the problem

Exercise H

1/1 point (graded)

Read the following text.

The purpose of this report is to determine the orbital elements of the future Earth observation satellite that will fly the GOCE mission. Interest will be focussed on the inclination, orbital altitude

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disturbance forces. A ground track of the orbit will show the path and thus the coverage of the future satellite and a reference to previously flown Earth gravity observation missions will be made.

The text is part of an introduction. Which function does it have?

- ☐ Background information
- ☐ Motive for the research (why was this report written?)
- ☒ Purpose statement / research question ✓
- ☐ Limitations / requirements
- ☐ Structural overview per chapter

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✓ Correct (1/1 point)

So the aim of an introduction is to prepare for reading your report.

On the next page, we move on to the Summary chapter.

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